

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

MEDIEVAL HISTORY 04

THE KHALJIS: ALAUDDIN KHALJI & MARKET REFORMS

Source criticism + state-capacity framing | not a modern command economy | Delhi-centred military-fiscal system

Core problem

Mongol pressure, noble conspiracy and fiscal strain pushed Alauddin toward an unusually coercive but highly integrated military-fiscal regime.

Analytical chain

Revenue extraction -> grain supply -> regulated prices -> affordable cash-paid cavalry -> frontier defence and expansion.

Essential cautions

Barani is indispensable but not statistically neutral. Chittor is not Padmavat. Deccan campaigns mixed tribute, plunder and selective annexation.

Delhi core

Siri, market controls, pay discipline

North-west line

Forts, cavalry, frontier response

Expansion arc

Gujarat, Rajputana, Malwa, Deccan

Original deterministic cover visual for Topic 04. Schematic motifs only, not a map or a statistical chart.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

Solved topic-specific MCQs

Verified and routed PYQs

PYQ 01 - UPSC Prelims 2022 GS-I (direct routed question; exact wording verified locally; official key unavailable locally)

Question: With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements:

1. The first Mongol invasion of India happened during the reign of Jalal-ud-din Khalji.
2. During the reign of Ala-ud-din Khalji, one Mongol assault marched up to Delhi and besieged the city.
3. Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq temporarily lost portions of north-west of his kingdom to Mongols.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 (b) 2 only (c) 1 and 3 (d) 3 only

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: (b) 2 only. Confidence: high.

Model explanation: Statement 1 is incorrect because Mongol pressure and penetration into the north-west predated Jalaluddin Khalji; Topic 03 already anchored pressure in Iltutmish's age and the later Lahore sack. Statement 2 is correct because the **1303 Targhi crisis** brought Mongol pressure up to Delhi and Alauddin's defended Siri position. Statement 3 is unsafe in the wording used and is treated as incorrect in this repository's validated Topic 03 explanation; Muhammad bin Tughlaq had frontier problems and diplomacy, but the statement as framed is not the standard established event.

Why this earns marks: It fixes the chronology by ruler, separates frontier pressure from the Delhi siege crisis and refuses to validate a statement only because it mentions a familiar Tughlaq name.

PYQ 02 - UPSC GS-I 2020 (verified adjacent source question; primary routing elsewhere, but directly valuable for Topic 04 source criticism)

Question: Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

Persian literary sources are indispensable for medieval India because they preserve the political language, moral anxieties and courtly horizons of the age. Yet they reflect the spirit of the age only if used with **genre and patronage caution**.

The strongest evidence lies in the Sultanate archive. **Ziauddin Barani's** *Tarikh-i Firuz Shahi* records rulers, nobles, market regulations and ideas of order from Balban to the Tughlaqs. For Topic 04, it is the key source for Alauddin Khalji's ordinances and price-control system. But Barani was a fourteenth-century aristocratic moralist; his hostility to the "low and ignoble" means that vivid numbers, motives and speeches need qualification.

Amir Khusrau's courtly works, including *Khaza'in-ul-Futuh*, illuminate conquest, ceremonial culture and Indo-Persian self-fashioning. His value for the Khalji age is enormous: Chittor, Gujarat and Deccan campaigns all pass through his courtly lens. Yet the same lens is panegyric. He celebrates power better than he documents administrative limits or non-elite suffering.

At the same time, Persian sources widen beyond bare political narrative. They capture elite ideals, religious debate, urban sensibility and the moral language of sovereignty. Their silences are equally revealing: peasants, women outside elite circles and regional society appear unevenly.

Hence, Persian sources do reflect the spirit of the age - but the spirit they show is mediated, courtly and argumentative rather than neutral reportage. They are most powerful when read against inscriptions, monuments, coins and other narrative traditions.

Why this earns marks: The answer opens with a clear thesis, uses named sources from the Khalji age, links each source to what it proves, and qualifies each source instead of treating Persian writing as transparent fact.

PYQ 03 - UPSC GS-I 2023 (verified adjacent Sultanate question; primary routing to broader administration/technology owners)

Question: What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did those technological changes influence the Indian society? (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

The Sultanate period did not invent technology from nothing, but it accelerated the diffusion and combination of several techniques in textiles, construction, cavalry management and irrigation. Their effects were strongest in **state capacity, urban life and long-distance exchange**.

In construction, the widespread use of the **true arch, dome and stronger lime mortar** transformed scale and skyline. Topic 04's Khalji phase is crucial here: **Alai Darwaza** marks mature scientific arch-and-dome construction, while **Siri** shows how military pressure could produce new defended urban forms. The impact was not merely aesthetic. Larger covered spaces, gateways and fortified capitals supported royal ceremonial and political control.

In military organisation, improved cavalry inspection through **dagh** and **chehra** under Alauddin Khalji shows technology as administration. Branding horses and maintaining descriptive rolls reduced fraud and preserved army efficiency under Mongol pressure.

In textiles and circulation, the broader Sultanate period saw wider use of the **spinning wheel**, the **cotton-carder's bow**, improved looms and market-linked craft production. This supported urban growth, merchant activity and the provisioning systems on which capitals depended.

The social effect, however, was uneven. These changes strengthened towns, armies, merchants and courts more than they emancipated cultivators. Monumental construction and military inspection served states before they served social equality.

Therefore, Sultanate technological change mattered profoundly, but its historical meaning lies in the interaction of technique with political power, urbanisation and unequal social structure.

Why this earns marks: It answers both parts of the question, uses precise Khalji-era examples, and converts technology into social and political consequences rather than listing devices mechanically.

Original broad-coverage MCQs

MCQ 01

Question: Which statement best expresses the repository's framing of the Khalji period?

A. It is best read through source criticism and state-capacity analysis. B. It should be described chiefly as a medieval socialist experiment. C. It is mainly a romance about Padmavati. D. It has no meaningful continuity with the Mamluk period.

Answer: A

Explanation: Topic 04 deliberately rejects ideological caricature and reads policy through sources, mechanism and scope.

MCQ 02

Question: The "Khalji revolution" most safely refers to:

A. the abolition of iqta assignments B. the widening of the ruling class beyond the old Turkish monopoly C. the replacement of all nobles by village headmen D. the immediate annexation of the whole Deccan

Answer: B

Explanation: Elite composition changed significantly, but society as a whole was not revolutionised.

MCQ 03

Question: Jalaluddin Khalji's political style is best described as:

A. identical to Alauddin's confiscatory style B. pure military despotism without any conciliatory element C. comparatively tolerant and support-oriented by Sultanate standards D. based on abolishing the army's frontier role

Answer: C

Explanation: His rule is remembered for attempting to soften some harsher features of earlier monarchy.

MCQ 04

Question: Alauddin's road to power in 1296 pivoted on:

A. a caliphal nomination received in Delhi B. a village assembly election at Kara C. his architectural patronage at Siri
D. the Devagiri loot, the Kara meeting and the murder of Jalaluddin

Answer: D

Explanation: Wealth from Devagiri and the Kara assassination underpin Alauddin's legitimacy problem.

MCQ 05

Question: In Topic 04's political-geography language, the Delhi-Siri-upper doab belt is:

A. the core enforcement and provisioning zone B. only a symbolic ceremonial landscape C. a distant tribute zone D. a purely literary construction of Barani

Answer: A

Explanation: This is where fiscal extraction, grain supply and price control were most deeply tied together.

MCQ 06

Question: The 1303 Mongol episode is most closely linked with:

A. the fall of Warangal B. the fortification of the defended Siri position near Delhi C. the capture of Siwistan D. the treaty with Ramachandra of Devagiri

Answer: B

Explanation: The Targhi crisis is the classic Siri moment in Khalji history.

MCQ 07

Question: Which pair is correctly matched?

A. Qutlugh Khwaja - Mabar campaign B. Targhi - conquest of Gujarat C. Ali Beg and Tartaq - Amroha defeat D. Malik Nayak - siege of Chittor

Answer: C

Explanation: Ali Beg and Tartaq are linked to the Amroha defeat of the Mongols.

MCQ 08

Question: In Alauddin's military administration, **chehra** refers to:

A. a branded horse-mark B. a tax on grazing C. a provincial iqta record D. a descriptive roll of soldiers

Answer: D

Explanation: Chehra helped prevent fictitious musters and false salary claims.

MCQ 09

Question: Gujarat mattered to Alauddin above all because of its:

A. ports, bullion and horse supply connections B. monastic universities only C. frontier snow passes D. role as the Alai Minar's stone quarry

Answer: A

Explanation: Gujarat's ports and wealth strengthened Delhi's fiscal and military position.

MCQ 10

Question: Ranthambore became a major Alauddin target partly because:

A. it housed the Diwan-i-Riyasat B. Hamirdeva protected Mongol fugitives and defied Delhi C. it was the main cloth market of the empire D. Jalaluddin had already annexed it completely

Answer: B

Explanation: Refuge to Mongol rebels and fort strength helped make Ranthambore urgent.

MCQ 11

Question: The safest statement about Chittor 1303 is that:

A. the Padmavat narrative is a near-contemporary documentary account B. no siege took place and the story is wholly fictitious C. a secure siege-and-conquest event later acquired a powerful literary afterlife D. Khusrau wrote only about Padmavati and not about conquest

Answer: C

Explanation: Historical siege and later literary romance occupy different evidentiary layers.

MCQ 12

Question: Malwa under the Khaljis is best described as:

A. a zone never touched by Delhi power B. only a tribute-paying Rajput state without direct intervention C. a purely symbolic claim in court poetry D. more directly brought under Delhi administration than many Rajput states

Answer: D

Explanation: Malwa is one of the clearer cases of stronger political incorporation.

MCQ 13

Question: Ramachandra of Devagiri is important because he:

A. was restored as a subordinate ally and became useful for later Deccan policy B. permanently expelled Delhi from the south C. built the Alai Darwaza D. wrote the Tarikh-i Firuz Shahi

Answer: A

Explanation: His restored, cooperative position shows that not all Deccan policy was immediate annexation.

MCQ 14

Question: Warangal under Alauddin is best characterised as:

A. an unquestioned Delhi province from the start B. a theatre of submission and tribute before later annexation under the Tughlaqs C. outside all Khalji military concern D. identical in status to the upper doab khalisa zone

Answer: B

Explanation: Tribute and submission came first; later annexation belongs mainly to the Tughlaq phase.

MCQ 15

Question: The main political purpose of the ban on elite banquets and marriage alliances was to:

A. encourage Sufi egalitarianism B. increase temple revenues C. break aristocratic coalition-building D. replace horses with elephants

Answer: C

Explanation: These ordinances targeted the social infrastructure of conspiracy.

MCQ 16

Question: Which statement about Alauddin's reported confiscations is most accurate?

A. They were irrelevant to noble politics. B. They abolished all land grants in every province forever. C. They were merely a poetic metaphor. D. They sought to deny nobles the wealth needed for autonomous rebellion.

Answer: D

Explanation: Confiscation and surveillance belong to the same anti-rebellion strategy.

MCQ 17

Question: In the revenue system of Topic 04, **khalisa** most directly means:

A. land whose revenue flowed directly to the imperial treasury B. temple-free land only C. a village committee D. a cash salary scale

Answer: A

Explanation: Khalisa is central to understanding why the doab mattered so much to Delhi.

MCQ 18

Question: Which rural groups are specifically targeted in the source tradition as privileged intermediaries?

A. qazis and muftis B. khuts, muqaddams and chaudhurs C. Chishti saints D. Multani traders

Answer: B

Explanation: They are the classic rural-intermediary trio in Alauddin's revenue debate.

MCQ 19

Question: The best reason to avoid calling Alauddin's price policy "socialism" is that it:

A. eliminated all market exchange B. guaranteed equal welfare to all cultivators C. was aimed chiefly at funding and disciplining a large cavalry under frontier pressure D. arose from nineteenth-century social theory

Answer: C

Explanation: The regime's primary logic was military-fiscal, not redistributive ideology.

MCQ 20

Question: Which institutional cluster most clearly belongs to market regulation?

A. Chihalgani, paibos, sijda and caliphal investiture B. Mansabdars, zat and sawar C. zabt, patta and qabauliyat D. Shahna-i-Mandi, merchant registers, banjaras and state granaries

Answer: D

Explanation: These are the linked regulatory nodes of the Delhi market system.

MCQ 21

Question: Sample prices such as wheat at 7 1/2 jitals per man are best used as:

A. reported schedule markers from Barani via Satish Chandra, with unit caution B. proof of uniform prices across every province and year C. official audited statistics from a modern revenue department D. evidence that merchants disappeared from Delhi

Answer: A

Explanation: They are useful only when accompanied by source and scope caution.

MCQ 22

Question: The grain-granary-banjara system mattered because it:

A. replaced all local mandis B. connected field extraction to capital provisioning under supervision C. ended the use of cash in the countryside D. removed the need for cavalry pay

Answer: B

Explanation: Without this chain, price controls could not stabilise Delhi in practice.

MCQ 23

Question: Which statement best captures the relation between market control and commerce?

A. Alauddin abolished merchants and trade itself. B. Merchants ceased to exist in Gujarat and Delhi. C. The system regulated and channelled commerce rather than eliminating it. D. Trade became irrelevant once grain was stored.

Answer: C

Explanation: State advances, registers and cloth inflow show controlled commerce, not no commerce.

MCQ 24

Question: One lasting economic significance attributed to Alauddin's agrarian reforms in Part I is:

A. the end of all village markets B. complete equality in rural society C. the destruction of the town-country relationship D. the furthering of a market economy and tighter town-country linkage

Answer: D

Explanation: Satish Chandra explicitly notes this broader structural effect.

MCQ 25

Question: Alauddin's reported stance on shara is best read as:

A. a reason-of-state position that qualified juristic neatness without making him a modern secular ruler B. proof that the ulema fully ruled the state C. evidence that religion was irrelevant to the Sultanate D. a direct constitutional theory of secular citizenship

Answer: A

Explanation: The issue is political expediency within a medieval idiom, not modern secularism.

MCQ 26

Question: Which monument is most directly tied to Alauddin's unfinished imperial ambition?

A. Sultan Ghari B. Alai Minar C. Quwwat-ul-Islam mosque D. Tughlaqabad

Answer: B

Explanation: Alai Minar expresses scale and incompleteness in the Khalji phase.

MCQ 27

Question: The safest statement about Hauz-i-Alai / Hauz Khas is:

A. it was wholly unrelated to Alauddin B. it was built by Akbar as a market reservoir C. the reservoir is linked to Alauddin, while Firuz later built around the site D. it was a Mongol frontier fort

Answer: C

Explanation: Topic 04 must separate original reservoir association from later architectural reuse.

MCQ 28

Question: Which source is contemporary but also overtly court-panegyric for Khalji campaigns?

A. Abul Fazl B. Ibn Battuta C. Barani's Fatawa-i Jahandari D. Amir Khusrau's campaign writing

Answer: D

Explanation: Khusrau is invaluable for atmosphere and sequence, but he writes from within court praise.

MCQ 29

Question: Malik Kafur's post-1316 importance lies chiefly in the fact that he:

A. became vice-regent and intervened decisively in succession politics B. restored Jalaluddin to the throne C. founded the Tughlaq dynasty D. led the first Mongol invasion of India

Answer: A

Explanation: His power after Alauddin's death exposes how unstable the succession structure was.

MCQ 30

Question: Qutbuddin Mubarak Shah is especially remembered in Topic 04 because he:

A. restored many of the earlier controls and tightened market regulation still further B. abolished many of Alauddin's agrarian and market controls to gain support C. permanently reunited all Deccan kingdoms with Delhi D. wrote Padmavat

Answer: B

Explanation: His reversals show how ruler-dependent the Khalji regime had been.

MCQ 31

Question: Historiographically, the most useful role of K. S. Lal-type readings in Topic 04 is to:

A. prove that Barani is unnecessary B. deny all military logic to the reforms C. remind us of the regime's coercive depth, while still qualifying total-control claims D. establish Padmavat as contemporary archive

Answer: C

Explanation: Centralisation-heavy readings help foreground coercion, but require scope caution.

MCQ 32

Question: The best concluding line for Topic 04 is that the Khalji phase:

A. ended all later institutional continuity in the Sultanate B. was simply a literary myth C. mattered only for architecture and nothing else D. combined major military-fiscal experimentation with impressive but ruler-dependent coercive institutions

Answer: D

Explanation: This captures both achievement and fragility.

Remedial MCQs - trap correction set

Remedial MCQ 01

Question: Which statement is the best antidote to the label "first socialist"?

A. Alauddin's controls were primarily military-fiscal, not welfare-ideological. B. Alauddin abolished all private property. C. Alauddin's state redistributed land equally among peasants. D. Barani called the system socialist.

Answer: A

Explanation: The policy aimed first at army affordability and Delhi provisioning.

Remedial MCQ 02

Question: The best correction to a romantic Padmavati-only reading of Chittor is:

A. the siege never happened B. the 1303 military event is secure, but the later Padmavat layer is literary memory C. Jaisi was Alauddin's court historian D. Khusrau wrote only about mirrors and romance

Answer: B

Explanation: This is the core source-critical distinction.

Remedial MCQ 03

Question: Which claim most clearly overstates the scope of Alauddin's price controls?

A. They were strongest in Delhi and linked core revenue zones to the capital. B. They relied on merchants, carriers and granaries. C. They operated with equal day-to-day depth across the entire empire from Delhi to Mabbar. D. They were tied to cavalry affordability.

Answer: C

Explanation: Empire-wide uniformity is precisely what the evidence does not securely prove.

Remedial MCQ 04

Question: Which statement best corrects a simplistic annexation narrative about the Deccan?

A. Every Deccan kingdom immediately became a fully administered Delhi province under Alauddin. B. The south had no significance for Delhi. C. Malik Kafur never crossed the Vindhyas. D. Tribute, treasure, restored subordination and later selective annexation must be distinguished.

Answer: D

Explanation: Political relations differed sharply across Devagiri, Warangal, Dwarasamudra and Mabbar.

Remedial MCQ 05

Question: Which statement best corrects misuse of Barani?

A. Barani is indispensable but must be read as a late, moralising aristocratic source. B. Barani should be ignored because he is biased. C. Barani is useful only when repeated by later legend. D. Barani gives modern statistical series.

Answer: A

Explanation: Topic 04 depends on Barani, but never uncritically.

Remedial MCQ 06

Question: Which statement best corrects a Mughal-first misunderstanding?

A. Dagh and chehra were first introduced by Akbar. B. Dagh and chehra belong to Alauddin's military control and were later revived or systematised by others. C. Dagh and chehra are only literary metaphors. D. Dagh was a temple tax.

Answer: B

Explanation: Topic 07's corrected provenance controls this point.

Remedial MCQ 07

Question: Which statement best corrects a communal overreading of Alauddin's agrarian reforms?

A. The policy had no fiscal logic at all. B. The policy affected only Muslim nobles. C. The majority of cultivators were non-Muslim, but the policy's core logic was fiscal-military and anti-intermediary. D. The policy was designed only as a spiritual discipline.

Answer: C

Explanation: Demography and fiscal logic must both be kept in view.

Remedial MCQ 08

Question: Which statement best corrects the idea that controlled markets meant the end of trade?

A. Merchants were abolished from Delhi. B. Gujarat ceased to matter once the market system began. C. Banjaras were military officers only. D. State advances to traders and capital cloth inflow show regulated commerce, not commerce's disappearance.

Answer: D

Explanation: The system disciplined trade but depended on traders and carriers.

Remedial MCQ 09

Question: Which statement best corrects overstatement about Alai Darwaza?

A. It marks a mature scientific arch-and-dome phase, while the earlier surviving true arch belongs to Balban's tomb in this repository's sequence. B. It is the earliest surviving true arch in the assigned sequence. C. It has no relation to Khalji political ambition. D. It was built by Firuz Tughlaq.

Answer: A

Explanation: This is a classic elimination trap in Sultanate art questions.

Remedial MCQ 10

Question: Which statement best corrects a simplistic reading of the post-1316 collapse?

A. Every Khalji institution vanished instantly without residue. B. The rapid succession crisis revealed dependence on the ruler's personal coercive grip. C. Alauddin had already created a settled law of primogeniture. D. The Tughlaqs inherited nothing from the Khaljis.

Answer: B

Explanation: Institutions remained, but disciplined obedience and succession control broke down.

Remedial MCQ 11

Question: Which statement best corrects a false reading of Jalaluddin?

A. Jalaluddin's reign has no ideological significance at all. B. Jalaluddin was identical to Balban and Alauddin in political tone. C. Jalaluddin's reported support-based rhetoric helps explain why Alauddin's reversal looked so sharp. D. Jalaluddin ruled after Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq.

Answer: C

Explanation: The contrast is central to understanding the Khalji turn.

Remedial MCQ 12

Question: Which statement best corrects misuse of the term "Khalji revolution"?

A. It means universal social equality under the Khaljis. B. It means no continuity at all with the Mamluk order. C. It means a mass peasant uprising against the Turkish state. D. It means a substantial change in ruling-class access and composition within a continuing Delhi Sultanate framework.

Answer: D

Explanation: This is the safest definition for UPSC use.

Original solved Mains practice

10-mark Question 01

Question: Was the Khalji "revolution" more a reconfiguration of the ruling class than a social revolution? Discuss. (Answer in 150 words)

Model solution:

Yes - in UPSC-safe usage the Khalji "revolution" is better understood as a **reconfiguration of elite access** than as a social revolution.

First, the local Satish Chandra evidence stresses that the rise of Jalaluddin Khalji ended the old Turkish monopoly of high office. Khaljis, Indian Muslims and other non-monopoly groups gained greater room in the ruling class. This is the strongest positive content of the phrase.

Second, the institutional structure remained recognisably Sultanate. Delhi stayed the centre, iqta logic continued, coercive monarchy persisted, and countryside hierarchy was not democratised. Alauddin's later regime was if anything harsher and more centralised than before.

Third, the population at large did not experience a social levelling revolution. Peasants still faced heavy extraction; nobles still dominated; military slavery and court hierarchy persisted.

Thus, the term is useful only when limited to **ruling-class composition and political access**. It becomes misleading when stretched into a mass social transformation.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, uses Satish Chandra's core insight, distinguishes elite from society and ends with a graded verdict.

10-mark Question 02

Question: How did Mongol pressure reshape Alauddin Khalji's state? Explain. (Answer in 150 words)

Model solution:

Mongol pressure pushed Alauddin Khalji toward a far more integrated **military-fiscal state**.

First, repeated crises - especially the 1299 Kili episode, the 1303 Siri-Delhi pressure and the 1305 Amroha battle - demonstrated that Delhi needed a large and ready cavalry. These events are securely anchored in the local OCR and PYQ routing.

Second, that army required affordable horses, reliable pay and fortified frontiers. Alauddin therefore strengthened the cavalry through **dagh** and **chehra**, repaired frontier forts and used a defended urban space at **Siri**.

Third, the fiscal base had to be deepened. Heavy revenue demand in the doab, cash realisation, grain movement and fixed prices all helped preserve the real value of soldier salaries.

Hence Mongol pressure did not produce only military response; it drove revenue reform, price regulation, surveillance and urban provisioning as well.

Why this earns marks: It converts frontier danger into an institutional chain rather than narrating battles in isolation.

15-mark Question 01

Question: Examine Alauddin Khalji's market regulations as an integrated military-fiscal system. (Answer in 250 words)

Model solution:

Alauddin Khalji's market regulations are best explained not as welfare economics, but as a **Delhi-centred military-fiscal system**.

The starting point was strategic necessity. The Mongol attacks of the late 1290s and early 1300s convinced Alauddin that Delhi needed a large standing cavalry. Yet a large cavalry implied recurring expenditure on soldiers, horses and urban provisioning. The state therefore sought not merely treasure, but a durable mechanism for keeping the **real cost** of cavalry manageable.

This is where agrarian policy and market policy converged. In the upper doab, land revenue was pushed toward **half of the produce**, khalisa control was strengthened, measurement was used where supported, and cultivators were drawn into cash-linked grain sale. Grain then moved through monitored channels - banjaras, mandis and granaries - into Delhi. On the urban side, the grain mandi, the cloth sphere, and the horse-cattle-slave market were supervised by the **Shahna-i-Mandi** and linked to the wider regulatory authority of the **Diwan-i-Riyasat**.

The result was a chain: **revenue extraction -> supply control -> regulated prices -> affordable cash salaries -> military sustainability**. Barani's sample prices, and the reported cavalry pay scale of roughly 238 tankas annually, make sense within this chain.

Yet the system had limits. It depended on coercion, intelligence, capital-city concentration and ruler-driven discipline. Its strongest evidence is Delhi-centric, and it frayed quickly after Alauddin's death.

Thus, the regulations were integrated, innovative and effective in context, but narrow in geography and fragile in durability.

Why this earns marks: The answer uses the required mechanism, names the offices, links rural and urban policy, and finishes with scope and durability limits.

15-mark Question 02

Question: Distinguish the secure political-military evidence on Chittor from the later Padmavat tradition. (Answer in 250 words)

Model solution:

The 1303 Chittor episode must be read through **source layering**.

The secure first layer is the political-military event. Near-contemporary courtly evidence, especially Amir Khusrau, anchors the siege, Alauddin's campaign context and the Khalji victory. The event fits the wider Rajputana strategy after Gujarat and Ranthambore. Chittor mattered strategically, not only symbolically.

The second layer consists of conquest rhetoric. Khusrau's world is a court-praised world. Massacre motifs, triumphal language and the silence on uncomfortable details must be read as part of panegyric, not as transparent field-reporting.

The third layer is later literary memory. The **Padmavat** tradition associated with Malik Muhammad Jaisi is much later. It transforms the historical siege into a Sufi-inflected romance of beauty, desire, kingship and honour. Its narrative power is immense, but it is not a simple documentary source for 1303.

Hence, the historian must separate three things: the secure siege, the courtly rhetorical framing of conquest, and the later symbolic afterlife in Rajput and Indo-Persian memory. The error lies not in studying Padmavat, but in using it unfiltered as if it were contemporary evidence.

A good UPSC answer therefore says: **Chittor 1303 is historically secure; Padmavat is historically important as later memory, not as straightforward eyewitness archive.**

Why this earns marks: It uses named evidence, honours literary significance without surrendering chronology, and shows exactly how source criticism operates.

20-mark Question 01

Question: "Alauddin Khalji's price control was neither socialism nor mere anti-merchant tyranny, but a Delhi-centred military-fiscal experiment." Critically evaluate. (Answer in 250 words)

Model solution:

The statement is broadly valid because Alauddin Khalji's price control makes the most sense as a **military-fiscal experiment** rooted in frontier pressure, noble politics and capital provisioning.

The evidence begins with the Mongol crisis. The Delhi-facing attacks of 1299, 1303 and 1305 showed that the Sultanate required a large cavalry under continuous readiness. A large cavalry, however, could not be sustained by windfall plunder alone. The state therefore needed to reduce the **real cost** of military maintenance.

This aim explains the interlocking structure of the reforms. In the upper doab, revenue demand rose sharply, direct khalisa control expanded, and measurement was used where supported. The grain thus drawn into state-visible

channels was pushed into Delhi through banjaras, mandis and monitored sale. In the capital, staple grain, costly cloth and horse-cattle-slave markets were supervised through registers, the Shahna-i-Mandi and punitive enforcement. The reported price schedules preserved the value of cash salaries. That is why the system was linked to cavalry inspection through **dagh** and **chehra**, not separate from them.

Yet it would still be wrong to describe the system as benign consumer policy. It rested on coercion, heavy extraction, surveillance and severe penalties. Nor was it simply anti-merchant. Merchants, especially in cloth and grain supply, remained necessary; some even received state advances. Commerce was disciplined, not abolished.

Finally, the system's limits are decisive. It was Delhi-centred, expensive to police, mediated by Barani's moralising narrative, and highly ruler-dependent. Its rapid weakening after 1316 shows that coercive brilliance had outrun institutional durability.

Therefore, Alauddin's market control was a remarkable but bounded military-fiscal solution - neither modern socialism nor irrational persecution of trade.

Why this earns marks: It directly addresses the quotation, uses named evidence, shows mechanism, rejects two false binaries, and closes with a balanced critical verdict.

20-mark Question 02

Question: Assess the achievements and limits of the Khaljis in expansion, elite control and state formation. (Answer in 250 words)

Model solution:

The Khaljis mark one of the Sultanate's most consequential phases because they combined **elite reconfiguration**, **territorial expansion** and **deepened military-fiscal state formation**. But all three achievements carried serious limits.

Their first achievement was political. The accession of Jalaluddin Khalji ended the old Turkish monopoly of high office and widened the social base of the ruling class. This did not democratise society, but it changed who could rise within the Delhi political order. Alauddin deepened this by recruiting and promoting non-monopoly elements, including Malik Kafur and other non-Turkish figures.

Their second achievement was military and territorial. Gujarat, Ranthambore, Chittor and Malwa extended Delhi's reach in the west and centre. Deccan campaigns under Malik Kafur opened Devagiri, Warangal, Dwarasamudra and Mabar to Delhi's fiscal and political horizon. Yet the limits were sharp: Rajputana was not uniformly administered, and in the Deccan tribute, plunder and restored subordination often mattered more than direct rule.

Their third and greatest achievement was state formation under Alauddin. Confronting Mongol danger and noble conspiracy, he built a large cavalry, imposed **dagh** and **chehra**, tightened the doab revenue base, regulated markets and provisioned Delhi. This was a genuine military-fiscal innovation.

But the limits were built into the system. Heavy extraction, ruler-centred coercion, Delhi-focused enforcement and a fragile succession order meant that detailed controls did not long outlive Alauddin. Malik Kafur's interventions, Mubarak Shah's reversals and the fall to the Tughlaqs exposed that weakness.

Thus, the Khaljis achieved a major expansion and an extraordinary hardening of the Delhi state, but they did not solve the problem of durable, impersonal institutional continuity.

Why this earns marks: It is organised by the exact themes in the question, uses concrete examples in each theme, and ends with a graded verdict instead of a flat celebration.